

THE AMBASSADOR

Continued 173 W.A.
Harriman papers Loc

~~SECRET~~

44 6-26 Stalin Harriman
Conversation. Molotov Conversation re Finnish
June 26, 1944. Situation ①

Present: The American Ambassador, Mr. Harriman
Mr. Edward Page, Second Secretary of
Embassy

Marshal Stalin
Mr. V. M. Molotov, People's Commissar
for Foreign Affairs
Mr. Pavlov, Soviet interpreter

Subject: The Finnish Situation.

After Mr. Johnston had withdrawn from the room, I had an opportunity to bring up with Marshal Stalin the question regarding Finland raised by the Secretary of State in a recent cable (Department's No. 1850, June 24, 10 p.m.) and I asked him whether in his opinion there was anything the President could do which might be helpful in facilitating the Finnish withdrawal from the war. The Marshal stated that he did not believe that any action on our part would be of any value at the present time. He said that the controlling members of the Finnish Government were Fascists, were agents of Hitler, and were under the complete domination of the German Government. They were not interested in the welfare of the Finnish people but only in keeping themselves in power.

The Marshal continued that at the instigation of the Finns, Boheman had approached Madame Kollantai in Stockholm and had stated that the Finnish Government desired to resume peace negotiations and to send representatives to Moscow. The Soviet Government had replied that if it received a written statement from the President of Finland or from the Minister for Foreign Affairs that Finland was prepared to capitulate, the Soviet Government would receive the representatives and would open peace negotiations. This had happened a week ago and no reply had been received from the Finnish Government.

I said that we had heard from our Chargé d'Affaires in Helsinki that there was a possibility of a change in government under Ramsay's leadership. Stalin replied "these are only rumors" and are typical of the policy of deception which the Finnish Government has been carrying on. For example, the Finns are continually deceiving the Swedes who, although honest, unknowingly mislead other

EHO
orig. Files

With concurrences
Declassify ☐ in part and excise as shown
EO 12958, Sec. 1.5 (2)
AUGUST 1964 by [signature]

people. Marshal Stalin did not appear to place any credence in the report that Ramsay was endeavoring to effect a change in the government; in any event he did not believe that Ramsay would be successful in ousting the "fascist group" which made up the majority of the Finnish Government.

In reply to my further question, Marshal Stalin indicated that he did not feel that assurances either to the Finnish Government or over its head to the people of Finland that the Soviet Government did not intend to swallow up Finland would be of any avail at the present time. At one time in the conversation Stalin stated that it was of course for the President and the United States Government to decide what course of action they wished to take regarding Finland. He added that he did not even believe that a rupture in American-Finnish relations would cause the present Finnish Government to change its position in so far as a Finnish withdrawal from the war was concerned.

In spite of the Marshal's pessimism, I obtained the impression that he would not resent or object to our giving informal indications to the Finns of our understanding of Soviet policy toward Finnish independence and as reiterated by Marshal Stalin in our last conversation.

EP:nn